were wondering why. The Army is just finishing laying its own OFC in 2023, twenty years later. They were definitely ahead of the times.

After the course, I was posted to the Perspective Planning Directorate in the Strategic Affairs Section as the Director, Concepts and Force Application, North (C&FA–N). Isha asked me how many men I had under my command (in RR, it was about 1200). I replied that it was just me and one clerk-cum-PA. Army HQ is a great leveller. The Director, North looked into the strategic issues affecting the national security of all the countries to our North and East, namely Nepal, Bhutan, China, Russia, and as far as Vietnam and Korea. The Director, West, Col Iqroop Ghuman, who had done the HC course with me, looked after Pakistan, Afghanistan, the CAR and CIS countries. The Director, Global, Col Madhok followed by Col Bhalla, looked after selected countries with which we had strategic interests: the US of course, but also Japan, Australia, France and the UK. The Director, Regional, a naval officer, looked after the countries in the Indian Ocean rim region, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and the Maldives. Between the four of us, we pretty much had the whole world at our fingertips. The fifth officer, the Director, Force Structuring, Col Jagbir Singh, to whom we gave our inputs, would then try to analyse what our force levels should be. All four of us Army officers in the PP (Strategic) Section rose to the rank of Lt Gen—Iqroop and Madhok becoming Army Commanders, the former serving under me when I became the Chief.

In the Strat Section, we were supposed to think futuristically and out of the box. We had to read widely and between the lines. This involved reading research papers by various scholars, keeping track of what world leaders have said and in which forum and findings of various think tanks, attending seminars

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